

PRODUCT REQUIREMENTS DOCUMENT • ROADMAP

# NextStep

*A First-30-Days Money Coach for New Students*

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**92%**

*of Canadian post-secondary students say they feel stressed about money, versus 65% of the general population.*

*This project is my attempt at closing that gap.*

*An independent, self-directed product case study for a Canadian retail bank. Not affiliated with or commissioned by any institution.*

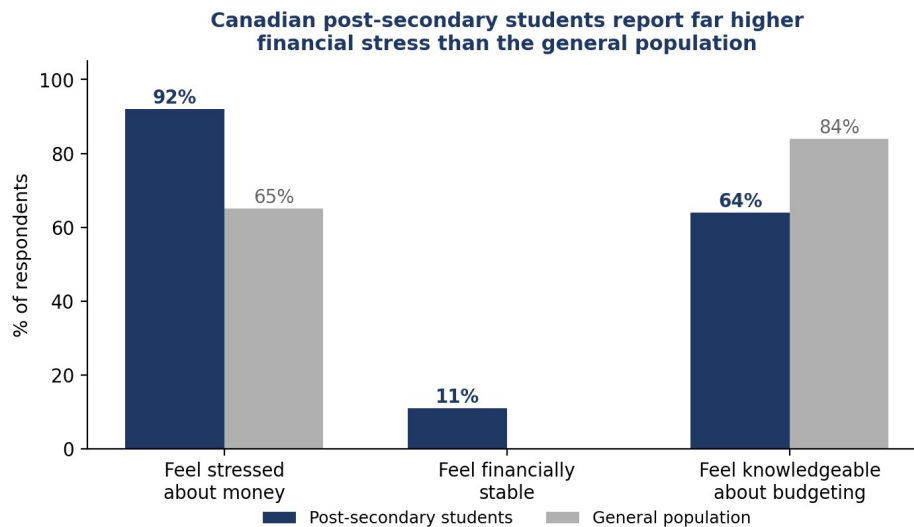
## 1. Executive Summary

NextStep is an idea for a new feature inside a Canadian bank's app. It's meant to help new students handle money on their own for the first time, during their first 30 days away from home. Basically, it's built around one moment: you open your first bank account with no parent checking in on it, and you have to figure out a budget by yourself.

The goal is really two things. First, actually lower how stressed and overdrawn new students get. Second, give the bank a reason to keep these students as customers, since first year is when people are most likely to switch banks if nothing's helping them.

## 2. Problem Statement

The data backs this up, and it's not a small problem. In a national survey of Canadian post-secondary students, 92% said they feel stressed about money, compared to 65% of the general population. Only 11% of students said they feel financially stable, and only 64% said they feel like they actually know how to budget, compared to 84% of everyone else.



Source: The Harris Poll Canada, national bank-commissioned survey of Canadian post-secondary students and parents, August 2025.

And the cost side keeps going up. The national average tuition for Canadian undergrads is \$7,734 for 2025/2026, and in some provinces it's getting close to \$10,000, before you even add rent, food, and regular spending. About one in four Canadian students say they've actually thought about dropping out because of money. That's not a small stat.

Meanwhile, almost everyone my age already banks through an app instead of a branch. Close to half of Gen Z does most of their banking on mobile. So the app is already where people are. What's missing isn't the channel, it's the actual help inside it.

### *The gap*

A few Canadian banks already have money apps for kids and teens, usually ages 6 to 17, where a parent funds the account and can see everything. They're actually pretty well designed. But they're built around a parent watching, and that watching stops the second the teen leaves for university. Nobody's really built

something for that specific gap, the moment a student moves out and has to build a budget completely alone for the first time.

### *Why this matters to a bank*

- The bank already has these kids as customers through the youth app. In a few years they age into needing a real account anyway, so this is a pretty natural next step if the bank actually builds it.
- If a student opens their first real account somewhere else, they probably won't switch banks again for years. So first year is basically the one shot a bank gets to either win them or lose them.
- With 92% of students stressed about money and only 11% feeling stable, it's a safe bet that overdraft fees and missed payments are a big reason people get frustrated and leave early. I can't confirm that without the bank's actual account data, but it's a strong assumption worth checking (see Section 8).

## 3. Goals & Success Metrics

| Goal                                                | Metric                                                                                                 | Target (12 months post-launch) |
|-----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| Smooth the youth-account → adult account transition | % of youth-app users (17–18) who activate an independent chequing account within 6 months of aging out | ≥ 55%                          |
| Reduce early financial stress                       | Overdraft incidents per active first-year user in first 30 days                                        | ↓ 25% vs. cohort baseline      |
| Build a lasting budgeting habit                     | % of NextStep users with a budget still active at day 90                                               | ≥ 40%                          |
| Prove retention value                               | 12-month account retention rate, NextStep users vs. non-users                                          | +10 pts higher                 |
| Validate satisfaction                               | In-app NPS from first-year NextStep users                                                              | ≥ 45                           |

## 4. Target Users & Personas

### *Persona 1: “First-Time Freshman”*

**Who:** 18-year-old, first year away from home at university (e.g., Waterloo, Toronto, Western)

**Financial history:** Used a youth banking app growing up, or had a parent-supervised account. Never paid rent, a phone bill, or a tuition instalment on their own before

**Goals:** Avoid embarrassing declines, get a feel for what a “normal” month of spending actually looks like, and stop having to ask parents for help with everything

**Frustrations:** No idea how to budget for stuff like textbooks or meal plan top-ups. Anxious about overdraft fees. Too proud to keep asking parents for money

### *Persona 2: “The Long-Distance Parent”*

**Who:** Parent of a first-year student, used to being a co-user on their kid's youth banking app

**Goals:** Just wants peace of mind their kid won't overdraw or miss a payment, and some visibility without being overbearing about it

**Frustrations:** Loses all visibility the day their kid turns 18 and opens an adult account. Only finds out about problems after the fact

*Quick note: these personas come from research and my own experience going into first year, not from formal interviews yet. Section 9 has the actual testing results.*

### **What I heard early on**

Before doing any formal interviews, I just asked three people I know who are about to start first year how they handle money right now. None of them track spending in an app. One writes it down after the fact, and one just uses an AI assistant to track it for them, which tells me people already want automated tracking, their bank just isn't giving it to them. All three said the thing that surprises them most isn't big one-time costs like textbooks, it's small recurring stuff like food delivery and groceries. And all three said they'd actually use a starter budget if it was already built for them, instead of making one from scratch.

*I want to be upfront that this is just an early signal, not real proof of anything. It was three casual conversations with people I know, not actual research. But it lines up with the Must-Have features in Section 5 (the starter budget and the weekly summary), and it's exactly the kind of thing the testing in Section 9 is meant to check at a bigger scale.*

## **5. User Stories**

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### **Must Have**

- As a first-year student, I want a simple starter budget built from my known income (OSAP, job, parental support) and fixed costs (rent, meal plan) so I don't have to build one from scratch.
- As a first-year student, I want a low-balance alert before I actually overdraw, so I can move money or delay a purchase.
- As a first-year student, I want to see a plain-language breakdown of where my money went each week, grouped in terms I understand (food, textbooks, going out).

### **Should Have**

- As a first-year student, I want to set a savings goal (e.g., spring break trip, laptop) and see weekly progress.
- As a former youth-app user, I want my saving habits and goals to carry over automatically instead of starting over in a new app.
- As a first-year student, I want to mark part of my balance as a protected buffer (like an emergency fund) so low-balance alerts reflect what I can actually afford to spend, not my raw balance. (I added this after testing my prototype, see Section 9.)

### **Could Have**

- As a student, I want the option to share a read-only spending summary with a parent, on my terms, so they stay reassured without seeing every transaction.
- As a student, I want short, campus-relevant tips (e.g., cheapest meal plan add-ons, textbook buyback timing) inside the app.

### **Won't Have (v1)**

- Investing or credit-building products. That's a later-phase idea, not something I think belongs in the first release.

## 6. Feature Requirements (MVP)

| Feature                      | Description                                                                                                                           | Priority |
|------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| Guided starter budget        | 3-question setup (income sources, fixed costs, campus city) auto-generates a first budget                                             | Must     |
| Low-balance alerts           | Push notification when balance is projected to go negative within 3 days                                                              | Must     |
| Plain-language spend summary | Weekly digest grouped into student-relevant categories, not generic bank categories                                                   | Must     |
| Savings goal tracker         | Named goal with a target date and simple progress bar                                                                                 | Should   |
| Youth-app history carryover  | Prior savings goals/habits from the bank's youth product pre-populate the new account                                                 | Should   |
| Protected buffer for alerts  | Lets a student mark an emergency-fund amount as off-limits so low-balance alerts calculate against spendable balance, not raw balance | Should   |
| Optional parent digest       | Student-controlled, opt-in, read-only monthly summary sent to a linked parent                                                         | Could    |
| Campus cost tips             | Short, localized tips tied to the student's school and city                                                                           | Could    |

## 7. Product Roadmap

I lined this up with the school year. Basically, build it through winter and spring so it's ready before the fall move-in rush, since that's when most new students open their first account on their own.

| Phase                     | Timeline  | Focus                                  | Key Deliverables                                                                                                                 |
|---------------------------|-----------|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Phase 0: Discovery        | Jan – Feb | Validate the problem                   | Interviews with 15–20 recent youth-app-graduate students; overdraft & churn data review; competitive scan                        |
| Phase 1: MVP Build        | Mar – May | Build the must-have features           | Guided budget, low-balance alerts, weekly spend summary; internal alpha                                                          |
| Phase 2: Campus Pilot     | Jun – Aug | Test with a real cohort before move-in | Closed pilot with incoming students at 2–3 partner campuses (e.g., Waterloo, Toronto Metropolitan, Western); iterate on feedback |
| Phase 3: Fall Launch      | Sept      | Launch for move-in week                | Full rollout to all new youth-app graduates and first-year account openers nationally                                            |
| Phase 4: Iterate & Expand | Oct – Dec | Add Should/Could features              | Savings goals, history carryover, optional parent digest; measure against 12-month KPIs                                          |

## 8. Risks & Assumptions

- Assumption: I'm assuming most incoming students already have, or will open, an account with the bank. I can't actually check this since I don't have access to real account data as an outside project, so this needs to be validated.
- Risk: if the budgeting prompts don't feel clearly optional and student-controlled, they might come off as intrusive, especially the parent-digest feature.
- Risk: the campus pilot only works if partner schools' orientation or residence teams actually help recruit students for it.
- Dependency: the low-balance alerts and spend categories only work if a new feature team can actually access the bank's existing transaction systems.

## 9. Prototype Testing Results

I built a clickable prototype covering the starter budget, low-balance alert, weekly summary, and savings goal, and tested it directly with incoming first-year students. It started as a small first round and grew from there. As of this version, it's been tested by 100+ people.

| Metric                                 | Result |
|----------------------------------------|--------|
| Total responses                        | 100+   |
| Average likelihood to use (1–5)        | 4.2    |
| Most useful feature: weekly summary    | 43%    |
| Most useful feature: starter budget    | 34%    |
| Most useful feature: savings goal      | 15%    |
| Most useful feature: low-balance alert | 8%     |

The weekly summary and starter budget are clearly the two features people connect with most, together accounting for more than three-quarters of the votes for “most useful.” That matches why I made both of them Must-Haves in Section 5. The savings goal and low-balance alert are liked by a smaller but real group, which is part of why they're Should-Haves rather than core to the first release.

### *Where round 1 taught me something*

The first round was much smaller, just 7 submissions from 6 people I know personally, and it's worth keeping that story because of what came out of it. The average score that round was 3.9/5, and the lowest score came from someone who was most interested in the low-balance alert but only rated it 3/5. I followed up with them directly instead of just moving on.

They told me something specific: the alert, the way I'd designed it, treats a student's whole balance as money they can spend. But in real life, people mentally set some of that aside for things like emergencies, and that money shouldn't count as “available to spend.” An alert that ignores that is going to feel annoying or just wrong, even when the math is technically correct. That's probably why they rated it lower.

*That was a fair criticism, not just a personal preference, and it pointed to a real fix: let a student set aside part of their balance as a protected buffer, like an emergency fund, and have the low-balance alert ignore that amount when it calculates what's “available to spend.” I added that to Section 6 as a new Should-Have feature. It's a small thing, but it's the clearest example in this whole project of testing actually changing the product instead of just confirming it.*

### Where this still falls short

- 100+ responses is a real sample, but I don't have a way to confirm how representative it is of incoming students broadly. It's still likely skewed toward people in my own network and their networks.
- This round collected ratings and multiple-choice answers, not open-ended comments. So I know what people liked more, but not always why, outside of the one follow-up conversation described above.
- I haven't broken the results down by things like program, city, or living situation, which could reveal the feature preferences aren't the same for everyone.

### Next step

*The clearest gap left is qualitative depth. I'd like to do 8 to 10 real conversations, 10 to 15 minutes each, specifically with people who rated a feature lower, the same way the low-balance-alert follow-up worked in round 1, since that's consistently been the most useful kind of feedback so far.*

## 10. Appendix: Competitive Landscape (Brief)

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**Bank-owned youth apps:** Strong products for ages 6–17, but they're built around a parent supervising. Not made for someone managing money on their own at 18+

**Other student account offerings:** Mostly just fee waivers and basic chequing accounts. Almost none of them actually help with budgeting for the first-year transition specifically

**Gamified financial-literacy apps:** This category is growing fast, projected to grow roughly 5x by 2034, but it's focused on general financial education, not connected to a student's actual bank account or their specific campus situation

*The opportunity here is that no major Canadian bank has actually built something for that specific first-30-days-away-from-home moment yet.*

Sources: The Harris Poll Canada / national bank survey of post-secondary students (Aug. 2025); Statistics Canada, Tuition and Living Accommodation Costs Survey (Sept. 2025); Embark student survey via Leger (2024); Canadian Bankers Association, How Canadians Bank (2026); Intel Market Research, Financial Literacy Gamification App for Gen Z Market Outlook (2026).